Einstein kept trying. In September, one month after graduation, he applied for a vacant Assistent position in mathematics at the ETH. He was rejected. In winter and spring he applied to Wilhelm Ostwald in Leipzig, Germany, and Heike Kamerlingh Onnes in Leiden, the Netherlands. From them he seems never to have received even the courtesy of a reply—though his note to Onnes is now proudly displayed in a museum in Leiden, and though Ostwald ten years later would be the first to nominate Einstein for a Nobel Prize. Even the letter to Ostwald from Einstein's father seems to have elicited no response.

To the saucy and strong-willed Mileva Maric, with whom his romance had turned intense, Einstein wrote on 27 March 1901, "I'm absolutely convinced that Weber is to blame. ... it doesn't make any sense to write to any more professors, because they'll surely turn to Weber for information about me at a certain point, and he'll just give me another bad recommendation." To a close friend, Marcel Gross-mann, he wrote on 14 April 1901, "I could have found [an Assistent position] long ago had it not been for Weber's underhandedness. All the same, 1 leave no stone unturned and do not give up my sense of humor . . . God created the donkey and gave him a thick hide."

A thick hide he needed; not only was he searching fruitlessly for a job, but his parents were vehemently opposing his plans to marry Mileva, and his relationship to Mileva was growing turbulent. Of Mileva his mother wrote, "This Miss Maric is causing me the bitterest hours of my life, if it were in my power, I would make every effort to banish her from our horizon, I really dislike her." And of Einstein's mother, Mileva wrote, "That lady seems to have made it her life's goal to embitter as much as possible not only my life but also that of her son. ... 1 wouldn't have thought it possible that there could exist such heartless and outright wicked people!"

Einstein wanted desperately to escape his financial dependence on his parents, and to have the peace of mind and freedom to devote most of his energy to physics. Perhaps this could be achieved by some means other than an Assistent position in a university. His degree from the ETH qualified him to teach in a *gymnasium* (high school), so to this he turned: He managed in mid-May 1901 to get a temporary job at a technical high school in Winterthur, Switzerland, substituting for a mathematics teacher who had to serve a term in the army.